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María Ballesteros

Contact Information

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Academic Positions

Geopolitics Postdoctoral Research Associate 2026–Present

William R. Rhodes Center for International Economics and Finance
Watson School of International and Public Affairs, Brown University

Education

Harvard University

Ph.D., Political Science 2026

A.M., Political Science 2022

Dissertation: *Essays on the Political Economy of Territorial Control During Conflict*
Senator Charles Sumner Dissertation Prize
Excellence in General Examinations
Committee: Jeffry Frieden (co-chair), Pia Raffler (co-chair), Gary King, Christoph Mikulaschek
Affiliate, Institute for Quantitative Social Science and Weatherhead Center for International Affairs

ITAM

B.A., Political Science, with honors 2018

Honors Thesis: *Indiscriminate Violence, Civilian Preferences and Insurgent Strategy: Evidence from Afghanistan*
Supervisors: Austin L. Wright (Harris School of Public Policy), Jeffrey Weldon, Alberto Simpser

Publications

2025. Ballesteros, María, Cynthia Dwork, Gary King, Conlan Olson, and Manish Raghavan. "Evaluating the Impacts of Swapping on the US Decennial Census" *CS & Law*.

Under Review

Ballesteros, María, Christopher W. Blair, Igor Kolesnikov, and Austin L. Wright. "Territorial Control in Civil Wars" R&R at *World Politics*.

Working Papers and Works in Progress

"Displacement as State-Building: Mobile Phone Evidence from the Taliban's Return to Power"

"Ripe for Entry: How Export Certification Draws Cartels In While Driving Violence Down"

Ballesteros, María, Christopher W. Blair, and Austin L. Wright. "Securing Property Rights as a Tool for Equitable Peace-Building: Evidence from Colombia's Land Tenure Formalization and Restitution Efforts"

"The Politics of Cartel Competition: Evidence from the Mexican Drug War"

"Mobile Phone Data Reveals the Immediate Effects of Civil War Termination on Migration Decisions: An Examination of the Taliban's Victory"

Policy Papers and Reports

2024. Ballesteros, María and Andrew O'Donohue. "There's a Better Way for Mexico to Elect its Judges" *Foreign Policy.*

Interviewed for *The New York Times*

Awards and Fellowships

2026	Senator Charles Sumner Prize for the best dissertation dealing with means or measures tending toward the prevention of war and the establishment of universal peace, Harvard University
2024–25	Minerva/Peace Scholar Fellowship, U.S. Institute of Peace & U.S. Department of Defense ($20,000)
2023	Empirical Implications of Theoretical Modeling Fellowship, Princeton University
2022	Research Award in Race, Ethnicity, Migration and Politics, Harvard University
2020–26	Graduate School of Arts and Sciences Prize Fellowship, Harvard University
2020	Honorable Mention, Premio de Investigación ExITAM (Best Undergraduate Thesis in Political Science)
2017–18	Junior Faculty Award, ITAM (awarded to top undergraduate students in the department)
2015	National Best Speaker, Mexican Universities Debate Championship
2015	Panamerican Second Best Speaker, Panamerican Universities Debate Championship, Montego Bay, Jamaica
2014	National Champion and World Runner-Up, International Public Speaking Competition, London, United Kingdom

Grants

2022	Weatherhead Center Mid-Dissertation Grant, Harvard University ($3,500)
2021–23	IQSS Summer Research Grant, Harvard University ($1,950; $2,400; $2,950)
2021	LATAM Regional Hub Small Grants Fund, EGAP ($13,800), with Christopher W. Blair and Austin L. Wright

Teaching

Instructor, Barriers to Peace: Organized Violence as an Obstacle to Development, Undergraduate Course, Harvard University, Spring 2026

Teaching Fellow, Comparative Politics of Latin America, Undergraduate Course, Harvard University, 2023 & 2024 (Steven Levitsky)

Undergraduate Thesis Advisor, Harvard University, 2022–2024

Instructor, Math Prefresher for Ph.D. students, Graduate Course, Harvard University, 2023 (with Sooahn Shin)

Teaching Fellow, International Political Economy, Undergraduate Course, Harvard University, 2023 (Jeffry Frieden)

Teaching Fellow, Quantitative Analysis and Empirical Methods, Graduate Course, Harvard Kennedy School, 2022 (Maya Sen)

Teaching Fellow and Guest Lecturer, Diplomacy and International Relations, Undergraduate Course, Harvard University, 2022 (Naima Green-Riley)

Head Teaching Fellow, Quantitative Analysis for Public Policy, Graduate Course, Harris School of Public Policy, University of Chicago, 2019 (Thomas Coleman,

Austin L. Wright)

Training and Certificates

2026	AI Fluency: Framework & Foundations, Anthropic
2022	GIS Institute, Harvard Center for Geographic Analysis
2018	Data and Public Policy, Harris School of Public Policy, University of Chicago
2017	Macroeconomics and Fiscal Legislation, UNAM
2016	Chinese Government and Politics, Hong Kong Baptist University

Skills

Software: R, Python, Stata, LaTeX, ArcGIS, QGIS

Agentic coding: Claude Code, Codex

Languages: Fully bilingual in English and Spanish

Citizenship: USA, Mexico, Spain

Other Research and Policy Experience

Research Assistant to Luis Martinez and Maria Angelica Bautista, Harris School of Public Policy, University of Chicago 2020

Full-Time Research Assistant to Austin L. Wright and Konstantin Sonin, Harris School of Public Policy, University of Chicago 2019–2020

Junior Policy Analyst, IRStrat Consulting, Mexico City 2018

Junior Communications Analyst, Cuantrix, Televisa Foundation, Mexico City 2017–2018

Conferences and Invited Talks

2027	International Studies Association (ISA) Annual Convention International Studies Association (ISA) Annual Convention
2026	NEWEPS-27, Princeton University Online Peace Science Colloquium Political Violence Workshop, Harvard Kennedy School
2025	APSA Annual Meeting, Vancouver, Canada Political Violence Workshop, Harvard Kennedy School
2024	Political Violence Workshop, Harvard Kennedy School USIP-Minerva Peace Scholars Convening, U.S. Institute of Peace & U.S. Department of Defense, Washington, DC
2023	Empirical Implications of Theoretical Modeling (EITM) Institute, Princeton University

Service

2022–23	Graduate Student Association Co-President, Harvard Government Department
2020–21	PSprep Advisor: helping students from underrepresented backgrounds apply to Ph.D. programs